

Chapter 84-1

The word "dream" was frequently mentioned during school days.

From elementary school to high school, every essay Liang Shi wrote about "dreams" was the same: she wanted to take her grandparents to see the ocean.

But it was always mentioned, never fulfilled.

They had actually made a promise—once Liang Shi finished her gaokao¹, they would go see the ocean together.

Liang Shi would plan the itinerary and take the two of them traveling.

Then once Liang Shi started university, they would go on a trip together every year.

But unexpectedly, before Liang Shi could even take her gaokao, her grandfather became seriously ill. Treating his illness exhausted all the family's savings. Back then, her grandfather lay in the hospital bed, and no matter how much anyone tried to persuade him, he wouldn't listen. He insisted on going home, desperately saying the hospital wasn't working and that he was fine.

But at that time, he was actually in so much pain he couldn't sleep at night.

Her grandmother even tacitly agreed with his decision.

Liang Shi knew—they wanted to save the money for her to attend university.

In the end, all the family's money was spent, but her grandfather still couldn't be saved. Her grandmother also collapsed in the kitchen one morning and never woke up again.

Liang Shi couldn't afford tuition for university. It was a regret.

But she didn't feel remorse.

Even though her grandfather couldn't be saved, they had all done their best.

But if she had taken that money to attend university, to her, it would have been like stepping over her grandfather's corpse to see the outside world.

That was too cruel.

Liang Shi stood up and looked toward the sea, gazing at the rising and falling waves. The ocean stretched boundlessly, connecting to the distant horizon.

Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu that she had never attended university. When she first started acting, she felt particularly inferior, feeling that she didn't deserve her position². So she worked desperately hard—she wanted to be worthy of others' affection.

She had always been moving forward, never stopping.

Liang Shi said, "I never thought I would stand under the spotlight. It all seemed like a dream."

"But you made it." Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder. "You're destined to be a person who shines brightly, to be liked by many people, to receive a lot of love."

"But later, the dream shattered," Liang Shi said softly.

"Why?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Where I come from, girls falling in love with girls isn't really allowed." Liang Shi's memory returned to before she left that place—the overwhelming negative press, the countless insults and humiliations. They dug up all her past, mocking her poor family background, her lack of upbringing, mocking her for not having attended university, mocking her for being a toad wanting to eat swan meat³.

"I've always liked girls, but I knew my profession wouldn't allow me to do so, so I kept my distance from many people." Liang Shi spoke with a slightly bitter smile.

Her light brown pupils gleamed with light, and Xu Qingzhu stood opposite her, right within that halo of light.

"I had already prepared myself to never love anyone for my entire life." Liang Shi sniffled. The sound of the waves seemed to accompany her like background music. The seawater that kept surging in covered her and Xu Qingzhu's ankles. When the tide receded, fine, soft sand clung to both their ankles. "I got used to traveling alone, sleeping alone, eating alone."

Xu Qingzhu's hand reached toward the area beneath her eyes, her fingertips gently stroking over her cold skin.

Liang Shi smiled gently. "I could live my whole life surrounded by liveliness, then return to solitude."

Xu Qingzhu's heart suddenly ached. Her voice also became gentle. "And then? Who shattered your dream?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "I can't really say it was anyone in particular."

"I can only say this was a weakness for me, so when others threw dirty water⁴ on me, I couldn't explain myself." Liang Shi's tears fell directly down, not even passing over her cheeks before landing on the beach, burying themselves in the fine, soft sand, then being swept into the waves. "But Teacher Xu, I really didn't do it."

"Didn't do what?" Xu Qingzhu asked gently.

Liang Shi's brow furrowed tightly, her voice choking. "I didn't grope her⁵ while filming. I never liked her either. I didn't stick my tongue out during kissing scenes. In fact, all our scenes together were camera tricks⁶. I never had any inappropriate thoughts about her. At first, I might have had a tiny bit of favorable feelings."

"She was quite cute-looking. She would sweetly call me 'jiejie'⁷, give me little snacks and hand warmers. During night shoots, she would bring me steam eye masks." Liang Shi said, "So there was a tiny bit of favorable feelings, but I knew I couldn't. I couldn't like any girl, so I kept my distance from them."

"But I didn't know that after the drama finished airing, she would say that I..." Liang Shi paused, "Then everyone was cursing me, cursing me for being so disgusting, for riding on the drama's popularity to stir up a CP⁸, saying I was throwing myself at her. I saw all those words. They..."

Xu Qingzhu's fingers landed on her eyelashes, and she sighed softly.

Liang Shi stared at her very seriously.

Xu Qingzhu placed her hand on her back, slowly and gently patting it, then leaned forward to embrace her.

Her head buried in the crook of Liang Shi's shoulder, her lips landed on the skin of her neck, kissing it softly.

It was a restrained kiss, purely expressing heartache.

Liang Shi's body stiffened. Xu Qingzhu said in a low voice, "Teacher Liang, I'm too cold. Can you hold me tighter?"

A moment later, Liang Shi draped her own coat over her, then threaded her arms through the narrow gap inside the coat and held her tight as she had asked.

The sea breeze blew from the distant ocean surface, stirring up waves in the sea, yet it only gently brushed over their bodies.

Under the black coat, they pressed tightly against each other, creating a new, tender little world.

Undisturbed by anyone.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu continued to ask, "What did they say about you?"

"They said I wasn't worthy of that person, that I wasn't qualified to win awards, and that my family members deserved to die... so early." By the end, Liang Shi's entire body was trembling.

Xu Qingzhu gently stroked her back, but her voice took on a crisp edge. "Was that person very good? Pretty? What was so good about her? Her intelligence or her looks?"

Liang Shi said, "They were all okay, I guess. Nothing particularly outstanding."

"Then how is our Teacher Liang not worthy?" Xu Qingzhu said firmly. "Our Teacher Liang is worthy of anyone. It's *her* who isn't worthy of our Teacher Liang."

Hearing this, Liang Shi chuckled softly, but only buried her head in Xu Qingzhu's neck, her lips lightly touching Xu Qingzhu's skin.

She asked in a low voice, "Zhuzi, I want to bite you. May I?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She didn't understand this strange quirk of Liang Shi's when she was drunk.

First, she had kissed the top of her foot, then brought her to see the ocean.

Now, wanting to bite her—compared to the previous two things, it seemed rather insignificant.

Especially in this kind of environment, in this kind of atmosphere...

Footnotes:

¹ **Gaokao (高考)**: The National College Entrance Examination in China, a highly competitive standardized test that determines university admissions. It is one of the most important events in a Chinese student's life.

² **"Didn't deserve her position" (德不配位)**: A Chinese idiom meaning one's virtue or ability doesn't match their position or status—essentially feeling like an imposter who doesn't deserve what they have achieved.

³ **"Toad wanting to eat swan meat" (癞蛤蟆想吃天鹅肉)**: A Chinese idiom describing someone of low status having unrealistic romantic aspirations toward someone far above them—similar to "punching above one's weight" but more derogatory.

⁴ **"Threw dirty water" (潑髒水)**: A Chinese expression meaning to slander or spread false accusations about someone.

⁵ **"Grobe her" (鹹豬手)**: Literally "salty pig hands," this is a Chinese slang term for inappropriate touching or groping, typically referring to sexual harassment.

⁶ **"Camera tricks" (借位)**: A filming technique where actors appear to kiss or have physical contact but are actually positioned to create an illusion for the camera without actually touching. Common in the entertainment industry to avoid real intimate contact.

⁷ **Jiejie (姐姐)**: Meaning "older sister" in Chinese, but commonly used as an affectionate or respectful way to address an older female, even if not related.

⁸ **CP**: Short for "coupling" or "couple pairing," referring to fan-created romantic pairings of actors or characters. "Stirring up a CP" means deliberately creating romantic buzz between two people for publicity purposes.

Chapter 84-2

Liang Shi's tone was cautious and careful: "Can I just bite you gently?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Okay."

As soon as the words fell, Liang Shi's teeth landed on Xu Qingzhu's neck. Her teeth gently bit Xu Qingzhu's skin, just lightly grazing—there was no pain, only a tingly, numb, itchy sensation. Xu Qingzhu's leg unconsciously rubbed against Liang Shi.

Liang Shi responded in kind.

After the leisurely grinding of teeth, Liang Shi ended it with a gentle bite.

Liang Shi's fingernail pads still rested on that patch of skin, wiping away her traces.

Even so, that area now had red marks different from elsewhere, as well as Liang Shi's teeth imprints.

Just gentle ones, tiny marks.

Xu Qingzhu simply asked her, "Why do you want to bite me?"

Liang Shi buried herself in her neck, her voice pressed low and coy: "Because I can't kiss you."

Xu Qingzhu's heart felt like it was struck by something. She continued to ask back: "Why can't you?"

Liang Shi shook her head gently, the ends of her hair brushing against Xu Qingzhu's skin. She said in a muffled voice: "I just can't. There's no why."

Xu Qingzhu said: "Why?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "This isn't me."

"Then who is it?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi said: "It's the person from before."

Xu Qingzhu said: "But what I see is still you."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "But if I kiss you... I'd have to take responsibility."

"You don't want to take responsibility?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi suddenly bent her knees, her body moving downward, her lips landing on Xu Qingzhu's right collarbone. She gently parted her lips and bit at the position of her collarbone.

Still the same as before—no force, just biting gently.

Her teeth grazed against that small patch of skin.

This posture and state wouldn't be comfortable for an Alpha, yet Liang Shi's hands rested on Xu Qingzhu's waist, slowly moving upward.

As if trying to please Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but let out a soft whimper and pinched her waist.

Liang Shi then stuck out her tongue and gently licked the spot she had just bitten.

Liang Shi said in a muffled voice: "Zhuzi, don't be angry, okay?"

That gentle voice carried a hint of pitifulness—it was impossible to get angry at her.

Xu Qingzhu only asked her: "Why can't you?"

"The current one isn't me." Liang Shi said: "It's not me..."

Xu Qingzhu turned these words over in her mind several times, then asked: "This is the original Liang Shi's body, so you can't kiss me—is that right?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Mm."

"But I kissed you before." Xu Qingzhu said: "Do you remember?"

The sensation from that day was exceptionally clear. In the cemetery, under that large black umbrella, Xu Qingzhu had grabbed her collar and pulled her body down, then their lips had pressed together.

The rain pattered down around them, isolating them from the entire world.

At that time, Liang Shi had felt Xu Qingzhu's sorrow and sadness.

Of course Liang Shi remembered that kiss.

It was just that she had simply regarded that kiss as Xu Qingzhu's emotional outlet when she was sad. She hadn't thought about it carefully.

She also didn't dare to savor it.

But on many nights, she would dream of that sensation—even including what happened afterward.

After waking up, she would always feel annoyed, then go wash her underwear.

Chapter 84-3

Liang Shi nodded in answer: "I remember."

"What about your body?" Xu Qingzhu asked: "Will it come back?"

Liang Shi nodded: "It will."

"Then would you want to take responsibility?" Xu Qingzhu asked her: "If you kissed me, would you take responsibility?"

Liang Shi shook her head and answered very honestly: "I can't."

Xu Qingzhu was so wonderful—there would be someone better to love her.

There was an official pairing¹!

Someone who could support Xu Qingzhu's career, help her rise step by step, and become someone above others.

But what about her?

She was just cannon fodder. Once she finished her tasks, she should go offline.

She couldn't take responsibility.

But when facing Xu Qingzhu, she often couldn't control herself.

So she wanted to just gently bite her, not bully Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu didn't ask why either. She simply released her arms from around Liang Shi, took a step back, and looked up at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi stroked her hair and said in a very soft tone: "In the future, our Zhuzi will meet someone better and have a life that countless people will envy."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her intently.

Liang Shi tucked her disheveled hair behind her ear, still wearing a gentle smile. "Our Zhuzi must be well."

These words sounded like a farewell.

But Xu Qingzhu grasped her hand, her voice mingling with the sea breeze: "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi responded softly: "Mm?"

As soon as the words fell, Xu Qingzhu stood on her tiptoes, leaned in, and kissed her on the lips.

In that instant, Liang Shi wanted to escape, but Xu Qingzhu had long seen through her tricks. Her arms fell around Liang Shi's neck, shackling her in place, making it impossible for her to flee.

The coat draped over her shoulders slid onto the beach.

The waves that kept rolling in washed over their ankles. Xu Qingzhu stepped her foot onto the top of Liang Shi's foot.

This way, she and Liang Shi were about the same height—she could look her in the eye without needing to stand on tiptoe.

After their lips parted, Xu Qingzhu held Liang Shi's neck and slowly opened her eyes, only to see Liang Shi staring at her in a daze.

The drunk Liang Shi naturally carried a bit of a dazed quality. When those eyes looked over, they were exceptionally affectionate.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers gently stroked the skin at the back of her neck. In the gaps between kisses, she breathed softly: "The memories of this moment are yours. The feelings of this moment are yours. The person standing before me right now is you."

Liang Shi subconsciously licked her lips that had just been kissed, her whole body burning hot.

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very light, quickly absorbed into the wind: "So the person I'm kissing right now is you. You don't need to take responsibility."

The waves washed in, and the two locked eyes.

Liang Shi's hand cradled the back of her head. She swallowed lightly—it was like music beginning to play, a long and gentle prelude surging alongside the sound of the waves.

Two seconds later, Liang Shi leaned in. One arm fell to the small of Xu Qingzhu's back while her other hand supported her neck.

Like the rapid drumbeats after a musical interlude ends, they fell in a dense, fine shower, carrying an irrefutable romance.

Liang Shi's hand landed on the skin of Xu Qingzhu's lower back. Xu Qingzhu's toes gently brushed against her calf.

Their bodies drew close in the cold, letting the sea breeze blow past them.

Footnotes:

¹ **Official pairing (官配):** In Chinese web novel terminology, this refers to the destined romantic partner written for a character in the original story—the "canon" love interest that the author intended.

Chapter 84-4

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Early the next morning, Liang Shi was woken up by the sun shining on her.

The moment she woke up, she heard the sound of waves. She thought she was hallucinating and draped her arm over her eyes, trying to soothe them.

Then she remembered that Zhao Xuning's place was by the river, so it might be the sound of the surging river water.

But after lying there in a daze for a few seconds, she realized that even if it was by the river, what she should hear every morning upon waking would be the sounds of busy traffic.

If the soundproofing was good, she shouldn't hear anything at all.

How could there be such obvious sounds of waves?

She opened her eyes and found everything was plain white. This wasn't Zhao Xuning's home—it was a very minimalist décor style. The enormous floor-to-ceiling windows let all the sunlight pour into the room, and looking out through the windows, there was the boundless blue sea.

The tide had receded, and quite a few tourists were already playing by the shore.

Liang Shi: "..."

It appeared she was the only one in the room at the moment, but there was the sound of water coming from the bathroom. Liang Shi was only wearing a camisole and underwear, with two bruises on her waist. Her pants were still on, though. Her black wool coat was hung on a coat rack in the corner, and there were spreading water stains on the floor.

Her tongue felt numb.

Liang Shi sat there in a daze.

The memories from after getting drunk gradually came flooding back.

...

Liang Shi was different from Xu Qingzhu—she didn't black out after getting drunk. She would just forget things at first, but as her mind gradually cleared, those memories would also gradually return to her.

All of them would come back, and she would even remember them more clearly than things she normally experienced.

Even the sensory memories would be more vivid than usual.

Liang Shi: "..."

From drinking the alcohol that had splashed onto Xu Qingzhu's neck at the restaurant, to sitting in the car arguing nonsense with Xu Qingzhu, then after returning home sitting on the floor and kissing the top of Xu Qingzhu's foot, going back to the bedroom and napping for a bit, suddenly waking up and being unable to bear the darkness in the bedroom, so she went to the living room and saw Xu Qingzhu gazing out the window.

In that instant, the impulse to go see the ocean nearly consumed all of Liang Shi's rationality.

With the alcohol going to her head, Xu Qingzhu had also satisfied her request and brought her to see the ocean.

At the beach, she thought of her grandparents, thought of everything that had happened in that world.

She, who had never opened up to anyone since those things happened, told Xu Qingzhu everything—all of it.

They kissed at the beach. The seawater washed over their ankles. And she remembered all the feelings, all the sensations of touch.

When their tongues were intertwined, she had undone Xu Qingzhu's buttons.

But she didn't go any further.

However intense the kiss was, the bodily contact was equally restrained.

Then she and Xu Qingzhu booked a room at a nearby guesthouse. After returning to the room, she sneezed three times in a row. Xu Qingzhu pushed her to take a shower. She hurriedly showered and came out to lie on the bed, hugging a pillow and saying she wanted to wait for Xu Qingzhu to come out because she wanted to hold her while sleeping. But before Xu Qingzhu came out, she had already fallen asleep.

...

End of recollection.

Liang Shi wanted to bang her head against the wall.

She wanted to cut off her head and kick it under the bed.

She wanted to cover her face and never see Xu Qingzhu again.

What... was she doing?!

She really had drunk too much—she had no rationality at all.

Why had she said those things to Xu Qingzhu, and even kissed Xu Qingzhu so recklessly?

Liang Shi buried her head in her palms, filled with regret, and decided to quit drinking from now on.

She always subconsciously treated this body as her own. Her own constitution rarely got drunk, so she had forgotten that the original owner's body couldn't handle alcohol well.

However, after her luck value reached 80, she did feel more light and at ease when using this body.

Mainly because the two of them looked exactly alike—even the small moles on their bodies were in the same places. It was just that when she first arrived, she discovered the original owner didn't have abs¹, and her physical fitness wasn't as good as her original body. Everything else was completely the same.

Oh right, the original owner also had one more gland than her.

She didn't know if her body would grow a gland after coming over, whether she would need to go through differentiation² or directly become someone without glands. It was hard to say.

Liang Shi also didn't know what the system would do when the time came.

But what Xu Qingzhu said last night was also right—the memories of this moment were hers, and the feelings of this moment were also hers.

Then this moment was her.

Liang Shi... she let out a heavy sigh.

Then she heard Xu Qingzhu's cool voice ring out in the room: "Teacher Liang, get yourself together and let's go outside to see the ocean."

Liang Shi: "...?"

She didn't dare lift her head at all, so she simply buried herself in the blanket.

Looking utterly timid.

Footnotes:

¹ **Abs (馬甲線)**: Literally "vest line," this refers to the vertical lines on the abdomen that appear when someone has well-defined abdominal muscles—essentially visible ab definition.

² **Differentiation (分化)**: In ABO dynamics, this refers to the biological process where a person develops into an Alpha, Beta, or Omega, typically occurring during puberty. It involves developing secondary gender characteristics including glands that produce pheromones.

Chapter 84-5

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "It seems Teacher Liang doesn't have the habit of blacking out after getting drunk."

Liang Shi said in a muffled voice from under the blanket: "I remember everything."

Xu Qingzhu laughed even louder. "So?"

Liang Shi: "..."

It was precisely because there was no "so" that she was like this!

She hadn't figured out her own feelings, nor could she escape her current situation.

Most crucially, Xu Qingzhu was going to have her own official pairing Alpha. The system had said that her OOC¹ could change details, but couldn't change major events.

So in this world, the major event was that the Alpha Lu Jiayi would fall in love with the Omega Xu Qingzhu.

In short, it was a story where two perfect people had to fall in love and get married.

She, this cannon fodder, had to go along with the circumstances and go offline. If she didn't... she might be forcibly punished.

Just like the previous original owner.

So even when Liang Shi was drunk, she had honestly answered Xu Qingzhu.

She couldn't take responsibility.

Liang Shi was even more frustrated now.

Xu Qingzhu, on the other hand, lifted her blanket. "With such nice weather, and we finally went out—aren't you going to go look at the ocean and get some sun? Consider it a celebration for you joining the production."

Liang Shi secretly opened one eye to look at Xu Qingzhu and discovered she was wearing a purple floral maxi dress with a knit cardigan on top.

Liang Shi was astonished: "You even brought clothes?"

"Bought them outside." Xu Qingzhu said: "I bought some for you too. Change into them in a bit. Why are you so unenthusiastic about going on a trip?"

Liang Shi: "...!!!"

Her eyes instantly lit up.

A trip!

Her side quest 2 was a three-day, two-night trip.

Liang Shi immediately got up. "Alright then."

This was a king-size room—as the name suggested, the bed was very large, enough to sleep four people.

Even bigger than the one they had at Repulse Bay before.

Liang Shi breathed a sigh of relief. It seemed she hadn't done anything more beastly to Xu Qingzhu last night.

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Xu Qingzhu didn't mind either way. Her word was her bond.

The kiss—Liang Shi didn't need to take responsibility.

She had simply done what she most wanted to do based on the situation at hand. The physical pleasure had triggered psychological pleasure. In that instant, she was so happy she wanted to cry.

That was enough.

As for what came after, she roughly understood that Liang Shi had some concerns, but she didn't think that was a problem.

But as for what exactly to do going forward, Xu Qingzhu hadn't figured that out either.

Right now they were in a legal relationship, so whatever they did was perfectly justified.

As long as both people were willing.

Simply seeing Liang Shi's expression this morning after she had remembered everything—she found it amusing and wanted to laugh.

How had she never noticed before that Liang Shi was so cute?

The kind that just made you want to tease her.

Footnotes:

¹ **OOO (Out of Character):** A term from fan fiction and roleplay communities referring to behavior that deviates from a character's established personality. In this context, Liang Shi's OOC behavior means she's acting differently from how the original cannon fodder character would have acted, which can influence the story's details but not its major plot points.

Chapter 84-6

While waiting for Liang Shi to wash up, Xu Qingzhu laid out the things she had bought from outside that morning. There were some simple cosmetics—she had only bought lipstick and sunscreen.

This tourist area didn't sell a complete selection of products, and they were all off-brand items she didn't dare put on her face casually. Only the lipstick and sunscreen were brands she had used before, so she only bought those.

She sprayed on sunscreen in front of the mirror, then applied lipstick.

Liang Shi quickly changed and came out, wearing the same style dress as Xu Qingzhu, but in light blue.

Both of them had good figures, and they could make even such ordinary maxi dresses look incredibly alluring.

The same style in different colors looked very much like couple's outfits, and the knit cardigans on top were also matching.

Liang Shi asked her: "It's already autumn—aren't you cold?"

"Didn't I buy leggings?" Xu Qingzhu said: "Put them on. Besides, the temperature by the sea is quite high during the day. It only gets cold at night."

At its peak, the day-night temperature difference could reach over ten degrees.

Liang Shi had her phone announce the weather and found that it was indeed warmer here than in the city, reaching twenty-three degrees.

She walked over and noticed there was also lipstick on the cabinet. She said in surprise: "You even bought this?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said: "Essential for improving complexion. I didn't sleep well last night."

Liang Shi's face immediately flashed with panic. "Huh?"

She might as well have written on her face—Does this have something to do with me? Is it my fault? Did something happen?

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly, twisted open the lipstick to compare it against Liang Shi's skin tone, then closed the cap again. "It has nothing to do with you."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was still on edge.

Xu Qingzhu handed her a hair tie. "Teacher Liang, can you help me tie my hair?"

Liang Shi: "Huh?"

"If you can't, then forget it." Xu Qingzhu put the hair tie back on the table. After what happened last night when she was drunk, Liang Shi, who was feeling incredibly guilty, immediately picked it up. "I can."

The black hair tie was looped around Liang Shi's wrist, paired with the bracelet Xu Qingzhu had bid on before. The silver and black colors complemented each other beautifully.

Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu for a comb, but Xu Qingzhu said the combs here were too soft and would hurt her scalp when combing, so she asked her to use her ten fingers as a comb instead.

Liang Shi's slender fingers slipped into Xu Qingzhu's hair, gently and slowly, as if giving her a scalp massage.

Liang Shi gathered her hair in her hand and asked if she wanted it lower or higher.

"Lower." Xu Qingzhu said.

"Two loops or three loops?" Liang Shi asked.

Generally speaking, two loops would be too loose, and three loops would be tight.

"Just tie it however you normally do." Xu Qingzhu said: "It doesn't matter."

Liang Shi: "...Alright."

In the end, Liang Shi still tied it with three loops, but she moved the hair tie back a bit so it wouldn't dig too much into her scalp.

A few strands of hair were left loose at the front, looking pure and beautiful.

Xu Qingzhu handed the sunscreen to Liang Shi, but halfway through, she pulled her hand back. "Should I help you?"

Liang Shi: "...How about I do it myself?"

Xu Qingzhu changed it to a declarative statement, opening the cap. "I'll help you."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu squeezed sunscreen into her own palm, then dotted it on several spots on Liang Shi's face. Her soft hands landed on her face and spread it out.

The height difference between them wasn't actually that big, but Xu Qingzhu always felt uncomfortable when applying it for her—her arm had to be raised too high. So she said softly: "Bend down."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi obediently bent down, making it more comfortable for her to work.

Delicate fingers glided across the skin of Liang Shi's face. Those fingers touched every inch of Liang Shi's face.

Liang Shi unconsciously pressed her lips together.

When Xu Qingzhu applied it to the corner of her lips, she suddenly asked in a matter-of-fact tone: "Did you feel your tongue was numb this morning?"

Liang Shi: "???"

Her pupils contracted. Her face seemed to say—Is this something that can be talked about?

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her. "Normal conversation. Is there a problem?"

Liang Shi: "...No."

In the education Liang Shi had received in the past, this kind of thing could only be kept in the dark. It was impossible to discuss it openly.

Especially since she liked girls—saying it out loud would get her mocked to death and secretly blacklisted.

But Xu Qingzhu said openly: "The base of my tongue feels a bit numb. The tip of my tongue seems to have been bitten through—it hurts a little."

"Huh?" Liang Shi was startled. "Where?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together but didn't show her. She just described it more precisely: "About a quarter of the way from the tip of my tongue."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu said expressionlessly: "Don't bite with your tongue next time. Haven't you filmed kissing scenes before? If you bite, the tip of the tongue will bleed. It hurts."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her mind went blank, but she used sheer willpower to answer Xu Qingzhu's question. "I've never filmed real ones. They were all camera tricks."

In order to keep her distance from others, she had never dared to film real kissing scenes.

With male actors, that went without saying—she had never had kissing scenes with them!

She had mostly played the second female lead who loved but couldn't be with the male lead, or in urban dramas she played workplace roles. She had almost never acted in idol dramas.

The only BG¹ idol drama she had acted in, the male lead died at the beginning, and it was basically all flashbacks. The stories interspersed in their memories were all very slow-paced, like a dish simmered over low heat. There was only one kissing scene in it, on a morning when the first snow fell—the two of them were supposed to kiss while standing in the snow.

But that male lead had a girlfriend at the time, and the girlfriend was a rich, beautiful princess type who was extremely jealous, so they directly called in a body double to film with her.

She wasn't too happy about it either, so she directly discussed with the screenwriter to delete that kissing scene.

They didn't even hold hands.

After hearing this, Xu Qingzhu frowned. "That's unprofessional of you."

Liang Shi: "...I do all my own action scenes. Using camera tricks for kissing scenes isn't a big deal. How can that be considered unprofessional?"

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment. "But that's creating dreams for the audience. Look at all those TV dramas we watched before—weren't they all real kisses?"

"That's not true. Several of them were obviously camera tricks." Liang Shi said: "Some even used body doubles—you could tell because the lip shape changed."

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

"Money is too easy to earn in your industry." Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue. "No respect for your own profession."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi huffed lightly. "If we're creating dreams for the audience, then we'd also have to stir up CP² during promotions. If it gets too much, we'd have to recreate scenes from the drama to give the audience their sugar³. As long as the audience doesn't move on, we can't break up the CP. Then what about our other projects?"

This actually stumped Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment. "Promote them together."

"That's too exhausting." Liang Shi said: "Actors are actors, characters are characters. Some things can only stay within the characters."

Xu Qingzhu felt she had a point, then steered the conversation back to before. "Then be more careful next time you kiss. Don't bite the tongue."

Liang Shi: "..."

There's going to be a next time?!

Footnotes:

¹ **BG (Boy-Girl):** A term used in Chinese fan communities to refer to heterosexual romantic pairings, as opposed to BL (Boy's Love) or GL (Girl's Love).

² **CP (Coupling):** Short for "couple pairing," referring to romantic pairings between actors or characters that fans ship together. "Stirring up CP" means deliberately creating romantic buzz between two people for publicity.

³ **Sugar (糖):** Internet slang for sweet, romantic moments between a shipped couple that fans enjoy. "Giving fans sugar" means providing romantic content or interactions that fans of the pairing want to see.

Chapter 84-7

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The air by the sea was humid with a salty, briny smell, but for Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu, who hadn't gone out for a change of scenery in a long time, it was already a very good way to relax.

During the day, this area was livelier, after all it was considered a tourist attraction, especially during the holidays.

The two strolled around the beach for a day, then went to a nearby scenic spot the next day.

Xu Qingzhu had also arranged to have dinner with the Su family on Sunday evening. Su Zhe had called Xu Qingzhu on Saturday night, saying he had already spoken to Su Yao. She was currently in a dazed mental state and was actively receiving treatment. When the time came, if Su Yao really wanted to see her, then Su Yao would also attend. If Su Yao didn't remember her, then Su Yao wouldn't attend for now—they would simply have Xu Qingzhu meet and greet the other Su family members first.

So after strolling around for two days, even though Liang Shi still had some hesitation, she had no choice but to return to the city with Xu Qingzhu.

The hesitation was because the system had said the trip needed to be three days and two nights, but theirs barely counted as two days and two nights.

However, Xu Qingzhu's reunion with the Su family was the most important thing.

Just thinking about it made Liang Shi nervous on Xu Qingzhu's behalf.

On Sunday afternoon, Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi were strolling by the beach when suddenly someone patted Liang Shi's shoulder from behind and called out intimately: "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu turned around at the same time.

The moment she saw who it was, Xu Qingzhu's face turned cold, while Liang Shi frowned. "Who are you?"

The other person looked pretty good, the pure and innocent type. Her temperament was somewhat similar to Xu Qingzhu's, but Liang Shi could tell at a glance that this was a budget version.

Liang Shi didn't recognize her, but clearly, the other person seemed to be very familiar with herself—no, with the original owner.

Upon hearing her question, the woman immediately threw herself toward her embrace. Liang Shi took a step back, and the woman grabbed at empty air, looking embarrassed.

Liang Shi extended her hand to block her. "Can I help you?"

The other person got angry too. "Liang Shi, I'm Wang Ruoshi! You haven't contacted me in so long. Didn't you say last time that you were going to divorce your wife? Why haven't you divorced yet?"

Liang Shi: "..."

What the f*ck.

"Why are you even out here having fun with her?" Wang Ruoshi said aggrievedly. "I couldn't even get through when I called you. Seriously, last time you left marks all over me, and it took me forever to recover. How can you say it wasn't you?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She instinctively looked at Xu Qingzhu first. She saw that Xu Qingzhu's expression was grave, and there was disgust in her eyes as she looked at Wang Ruoshi.

"It wasn't me." Liang Shi explained to Xu Qingzhu.

Wang Ruoshi whined coquettishly, "Last time you left wounds on my body, and it took me so long to recover. How can you say it wasn't you?"

Liang Shi said coldly: "Stop talking—"

Xu Qingzhu looked coldly at Wang Ruoshi and uttered only one word: "Scram!"